

1964

JANUARY 20

The North Vietnamese leadership decides in favor of an all-out war to defeat the South Vietnamese government and its American allies.

JANUARY 30

General Nguyen Khanh overthrows General Minh in a bloodless coup and takes power in South Vietnam. Other South Vietnamese generals contest his rule.

JUNE 20

General William Westmoreland is appointed commander of American forces in Vietnam.

JULY 1

General Maxwell Taylor is appointed US Ambassador to South Vietnam.

AUGUST 2

In the Tonkin Gulf Incident, the destroyer USS *Maddox*, on a signals intelligence mission, is engaged by North Vietnamese torpedo boats.

AUGUST 4

The US Navy mistakenly reports a second naval encounter in the Gulf of Tonkin.

AUGUST 5

US aircraft strike targets in North Vietnam in retaliation for the alleged attacks in the Gulf of Tonkin.

AUGUST 7

US Congress passes the Tonkin Gulf Resolution authorizing the president to take any action he deems necessary to assist South Vietnam "in defense of its freedom."

NOVEMBER 1

The Viet Cong launch an attack on America's Bien Hoa airbase outside Saigon, killing four US personnel.



ARVN and US troops under attack by the Viet Cong, 1964